

SMOKING AND LUNG CANCER IN AUSTRALIA

Where the risk lives, who carries it, and how it has shifted over the decades.

AT A Glance (2022)

10.6%

of Australian adults
Smoked daily in 2022,
down from over a
third in 1980.



9,191

Australians died of
lung Cancer in 2022,
the country's deadliest
Cancer.

70%

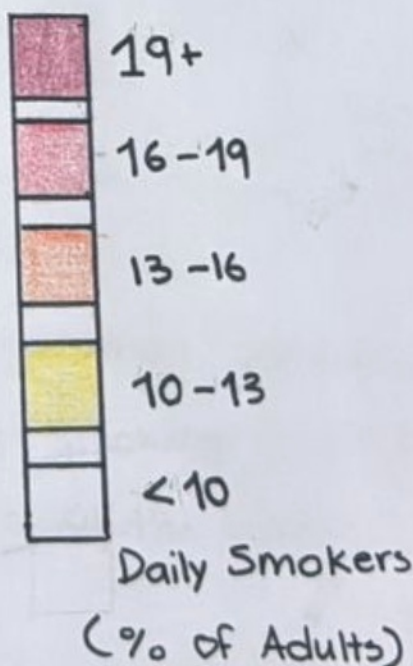
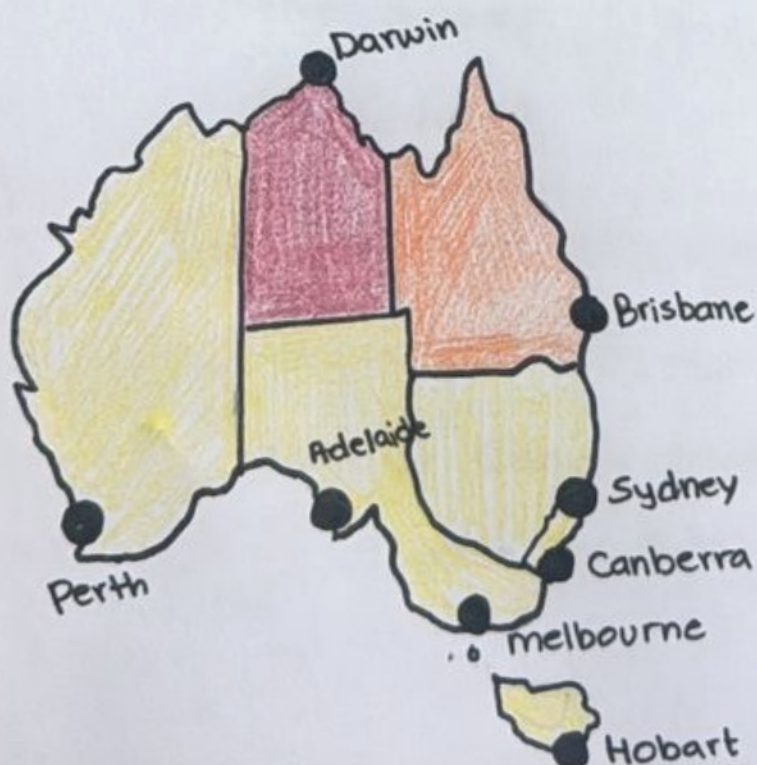
Fall in the Smoking
rate since 1980,
but Lung Cancer is
only beginning to
Follow.



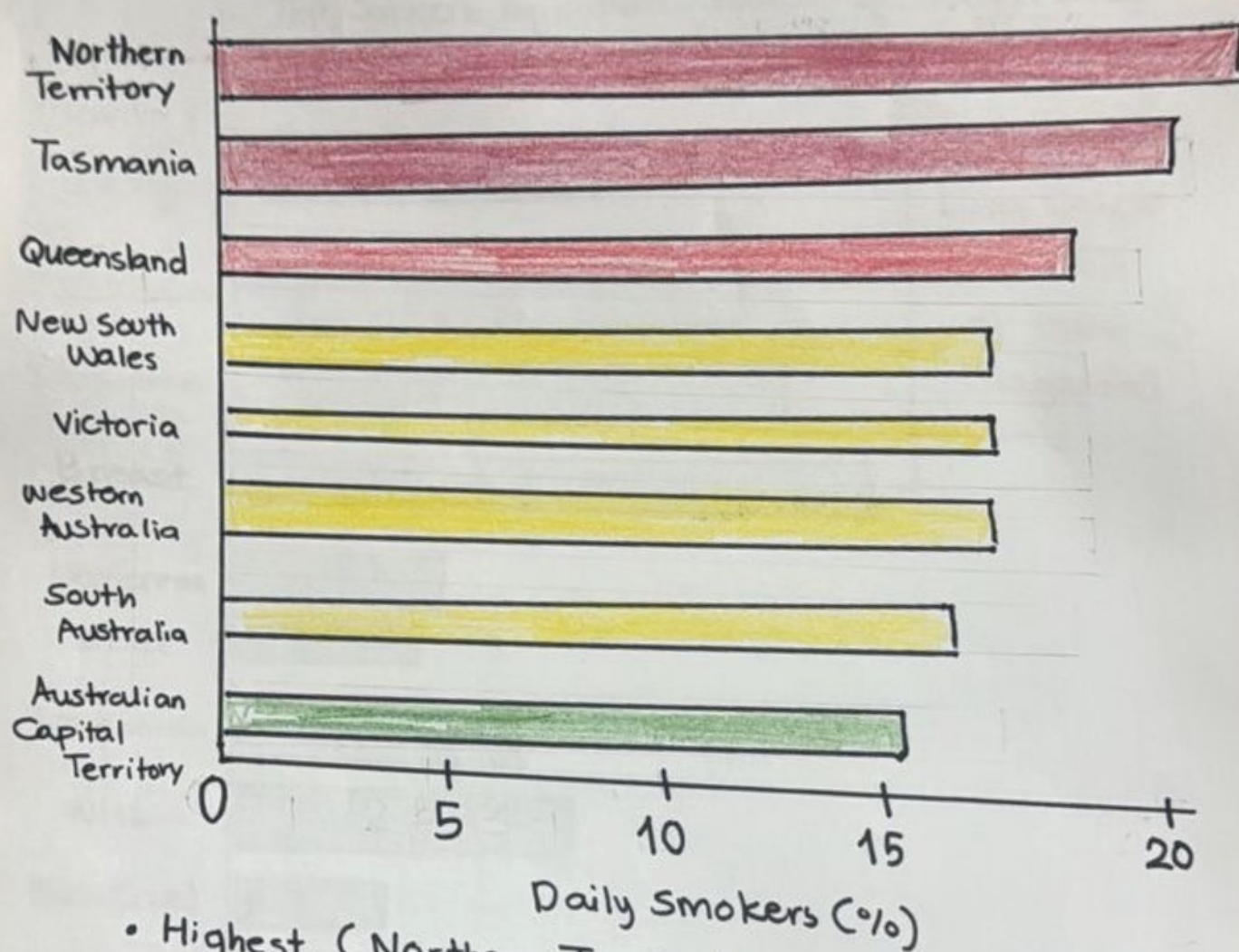
1. Where does Australia Smoke?

Smoking is not evenly spread. Remote and regional areas, especially in the northern territory, have higher rates. But because more people live on the east coast, most smokers live in just two states: NSW and Victoria.

1A. Smoking Rates By State (2022)



1B. States & Territories ranked by daily Smoking rate



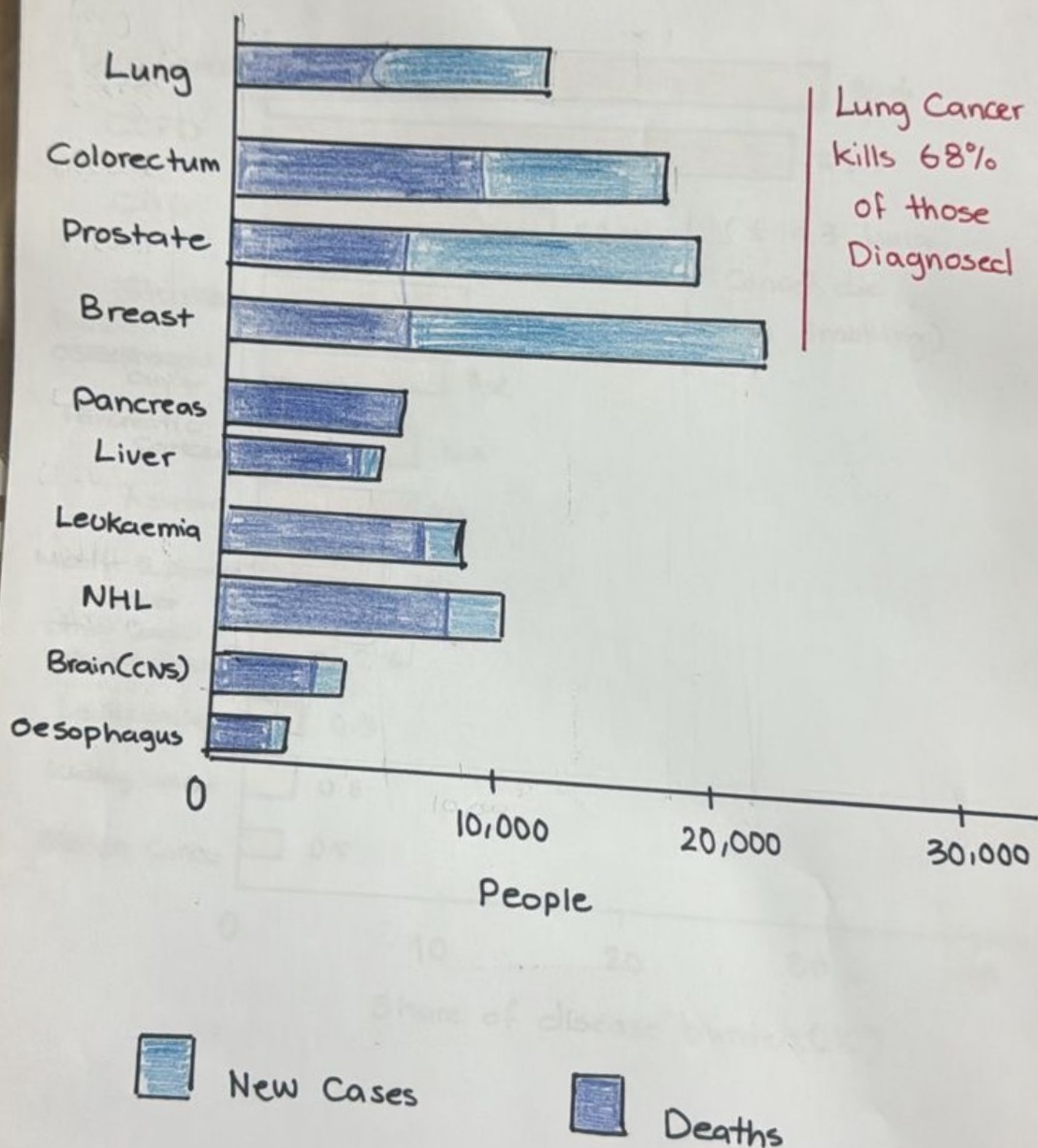
- Highest (Northern Territory)
- National Average (14%)
- Lowest (ACT)

2. The Cost of Smoking

Lung Cancer is the 5th most common cancer, but the first cause of cancer death, smoking fuels large share of the disease burden beyond the lungs.

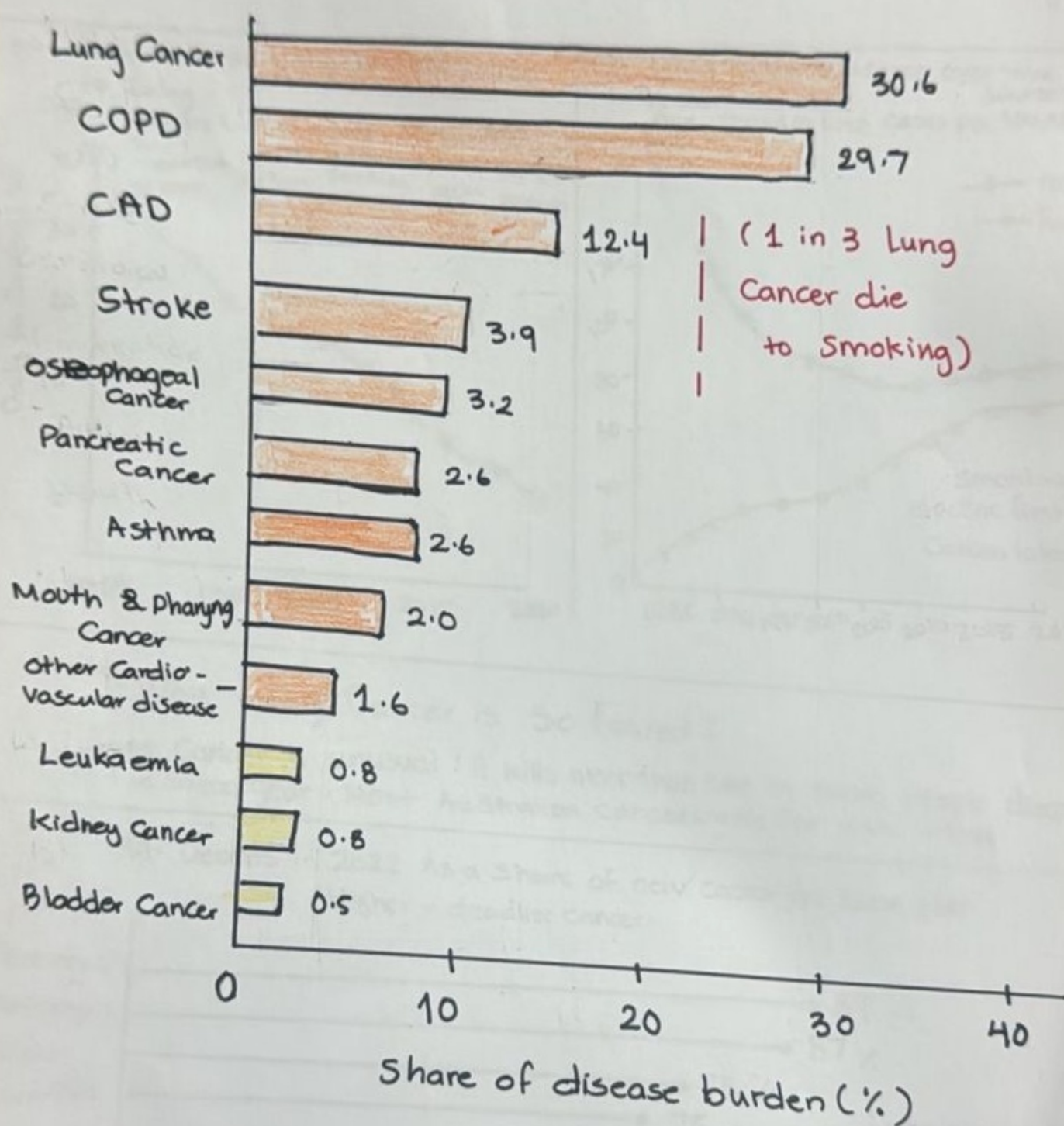
2A. New Cases (Light) vs Deaths (Dark), 2022

Top Cancers by impact. Source: Globocan/IARC



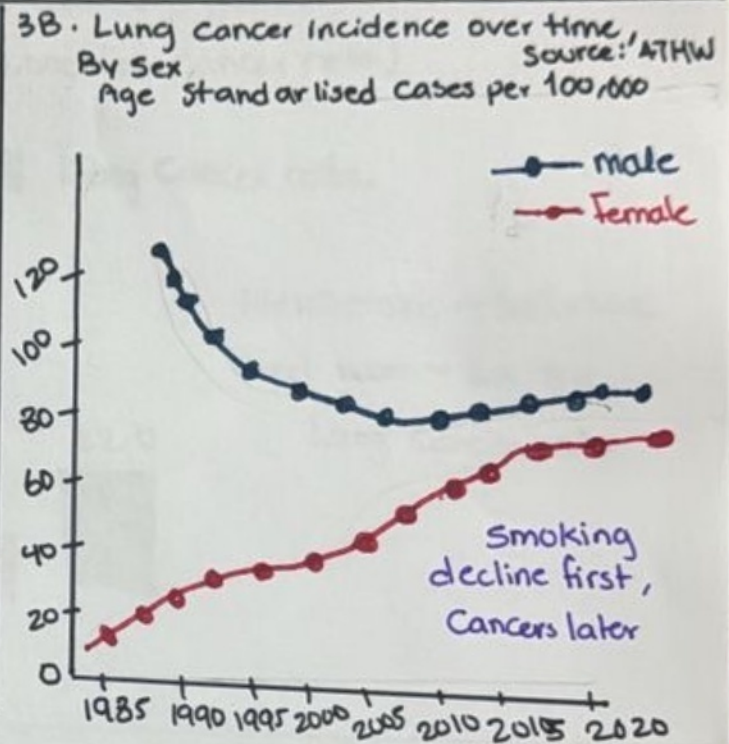
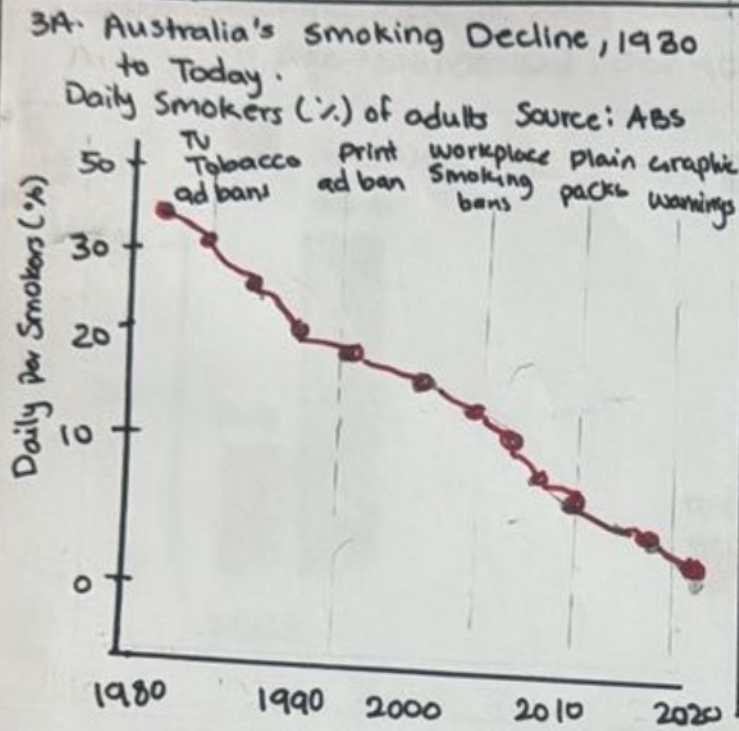
2B. Share of disease burden Caused by Tobacco

% of each disease's burden attribute to tobacco.



How was it changed over the decades?

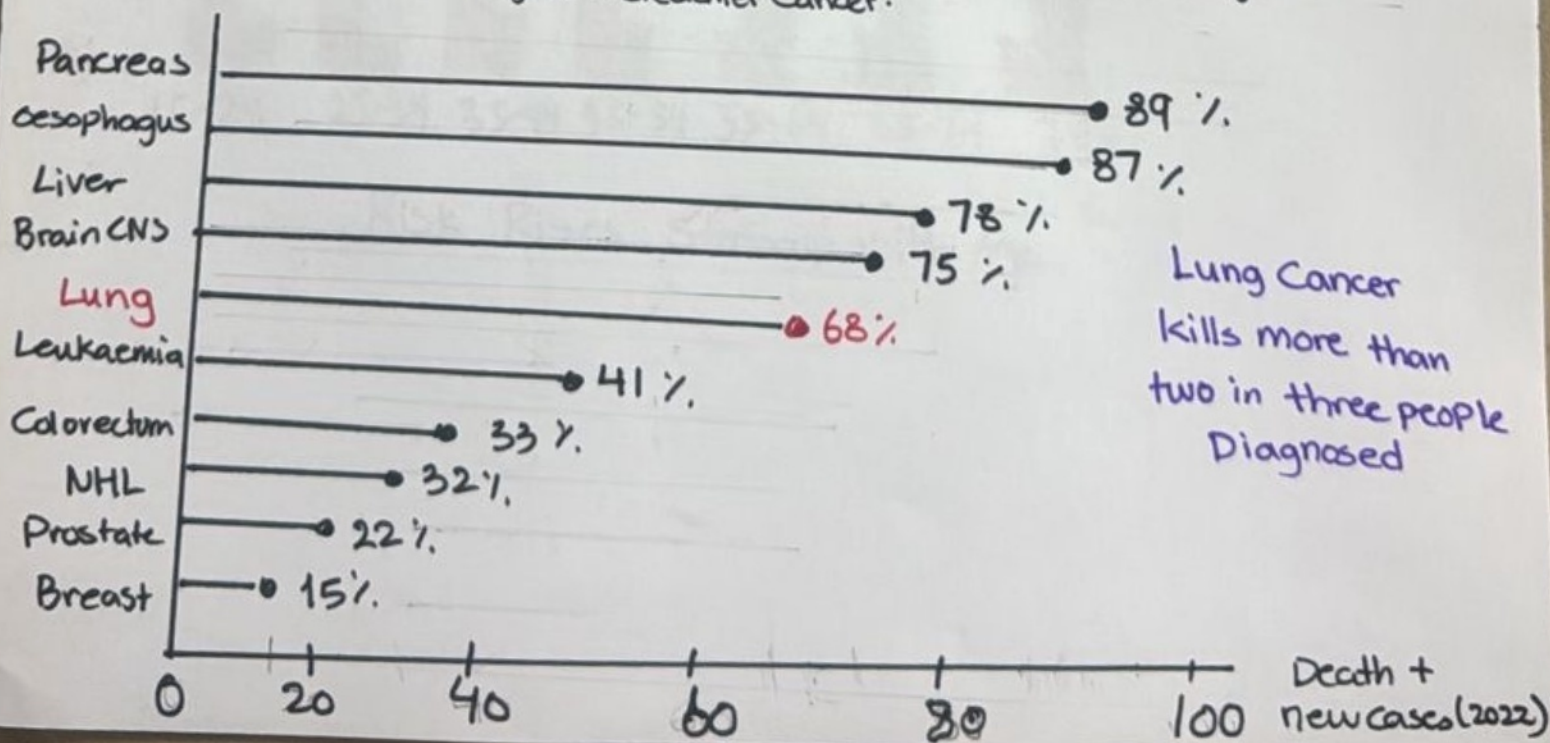
Smoking peaked in the 1960s and has fallen ever since.
Lung Cancer incidence followed, but only after a long delay.



4. Why Lung Cancer is So Feared?

Lung Cancer is unusual: it kills more than two in three people diagnosed in the same year. Most Australian cancers are far less lethal.

4A. Deaths in 2022 As a Share of new cases the same year
Higher = deadlier cancer.

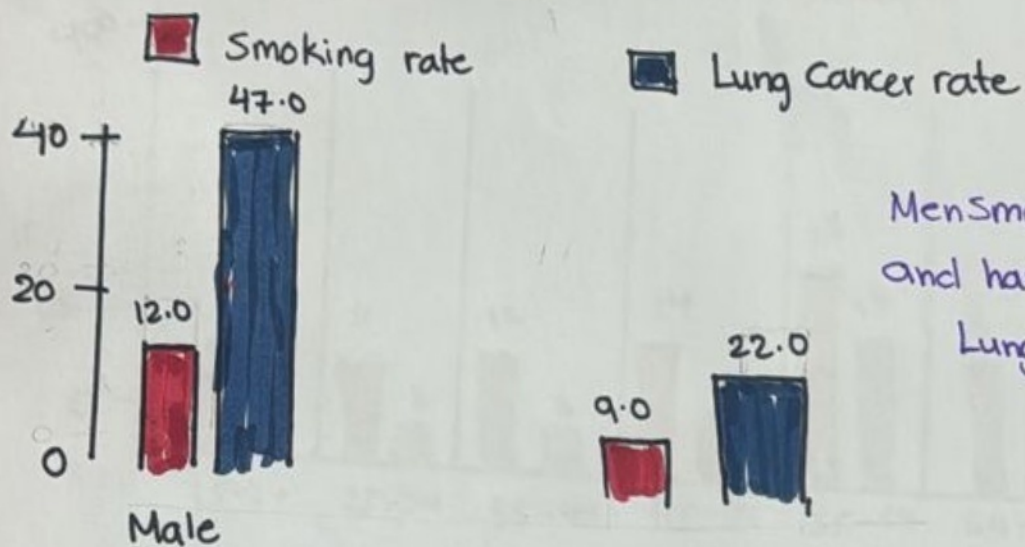


5. Who is most at Risk?

Risk is shaped by gender and age. Men still smoke more and are diagnosed at higher rates, though the gap has narrowed sharply.

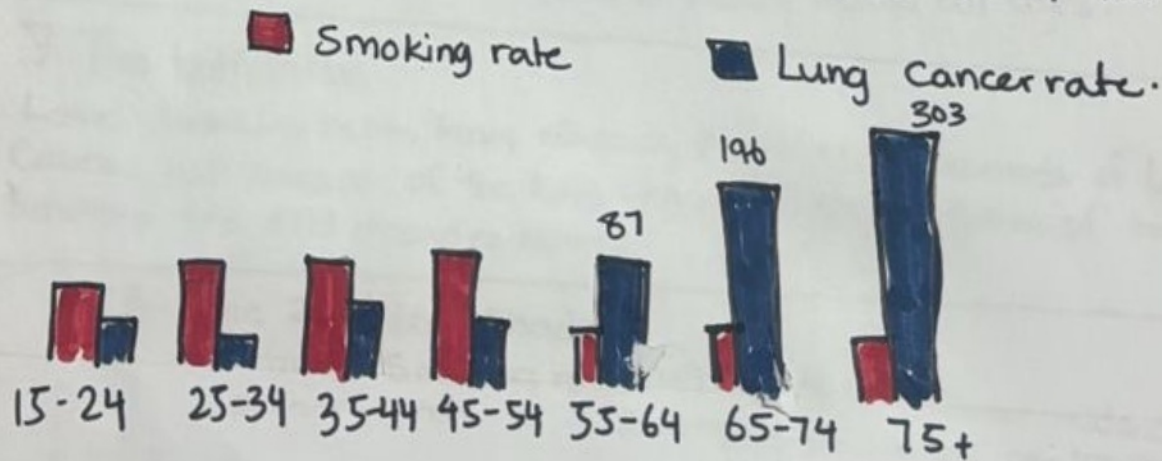
5A. Smoking Rate & Lung Cancer rate by gender

Age-standardised, Per 100,000 for cancer rate)



Men smoke ~32% more
and have ~2x the
Lung cancer rate

5B. Smoking & Lung Cancer rates by age group per 100,000

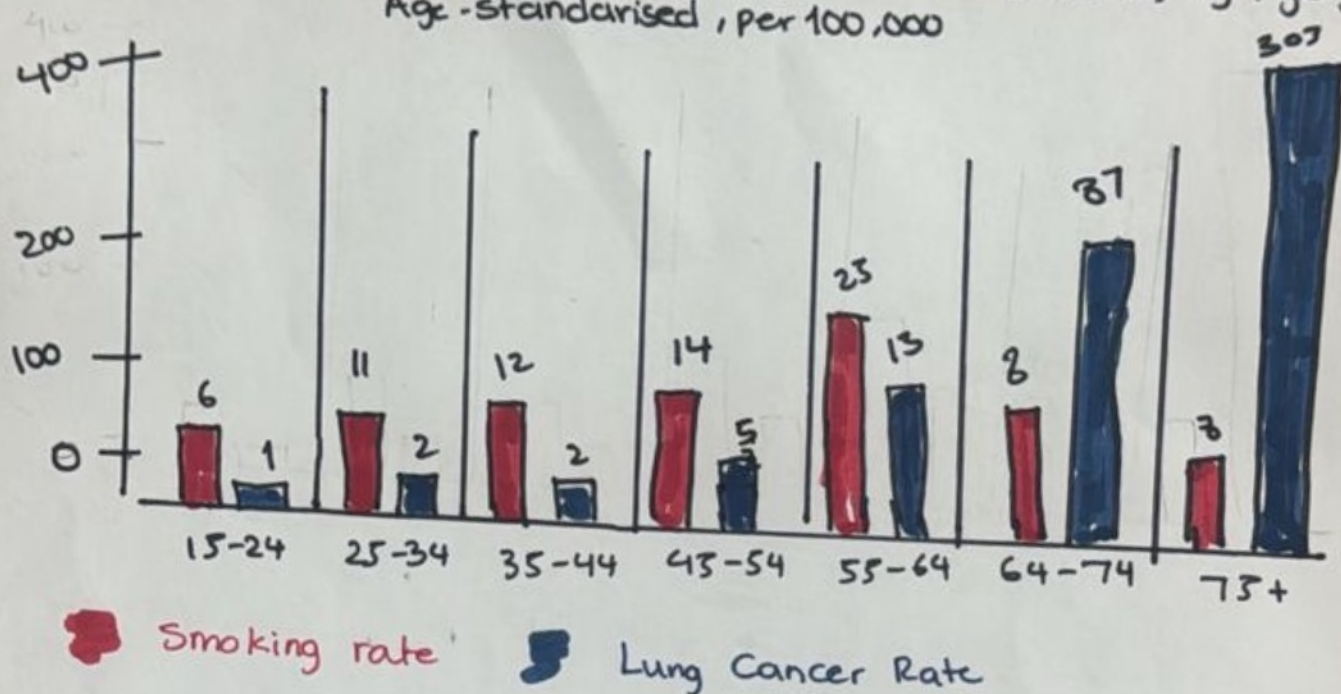


Risk Rises Strongly with Age

6. Decades of Delay

The lag between Smoking and disease is not just national; it shows up in every age band. Smoking peaks in middle age, but Lung Cancer rates only rise sharply two or three decades later.

6A. Smoking Rate (Red) vs Lung Cancer Rate (Blue) By Age group
Age-standardised, per 100,000



Two to three decades of delay across all ages.

7. The bottomline

Lower smoking rates have already prevented thousands of Lung Cancer Cases, but because of the long lag, the largest gains of today's Smokers are still decades away.

7A. The 25-Year Shadow

Australia Smoking rate (left Axis) & Lung Cancer incidence (right Axis)

